NEW VENTURE GUIDE

AI Agents & Automation Venture

Building workflows, custom AI assistants and AI agents with n8n, Make and Zapier for companies in the US, UK and Europe, delivered from Lahore

$52.6B	30%	~60%	4.35/5
AI agents market by 2030 (from $7.8B)	of work hours automatable by 2030 (McKinsey)	gross margin target	venture score

WHAT IS INSIDE

- Part 1: The basics: automation, assistants and agents
- Part 2: Why companies need it, and how big it is
- Part 3: Where to find the gap
- Part 4: Industries and sectors to target
- Part 5: Finance analysis and back-office agents
- Part 6: The services we sell
- Part 7: How the work gets done: toolkit and methods
- Part 8: The money: prices, costs and revenue
- Part 9: Where clients come from, and how we sell
- Part 10: Rules, security and risks
- Part 11: Launch plan and decision

As of 22 October 2026 | Figures marked "approx." are estimates and must be checked before money is spent

At a glance

Every company has people doing the same computer task again and again: typing invoices into a system, copying data between apps, answering the same emails, building the same Monday report. AI agents and automation tools can now do most of that. This guide explains the idea from zero, shows where the gaps are, which industries to target, and how we sell and deliver it from Lahore.

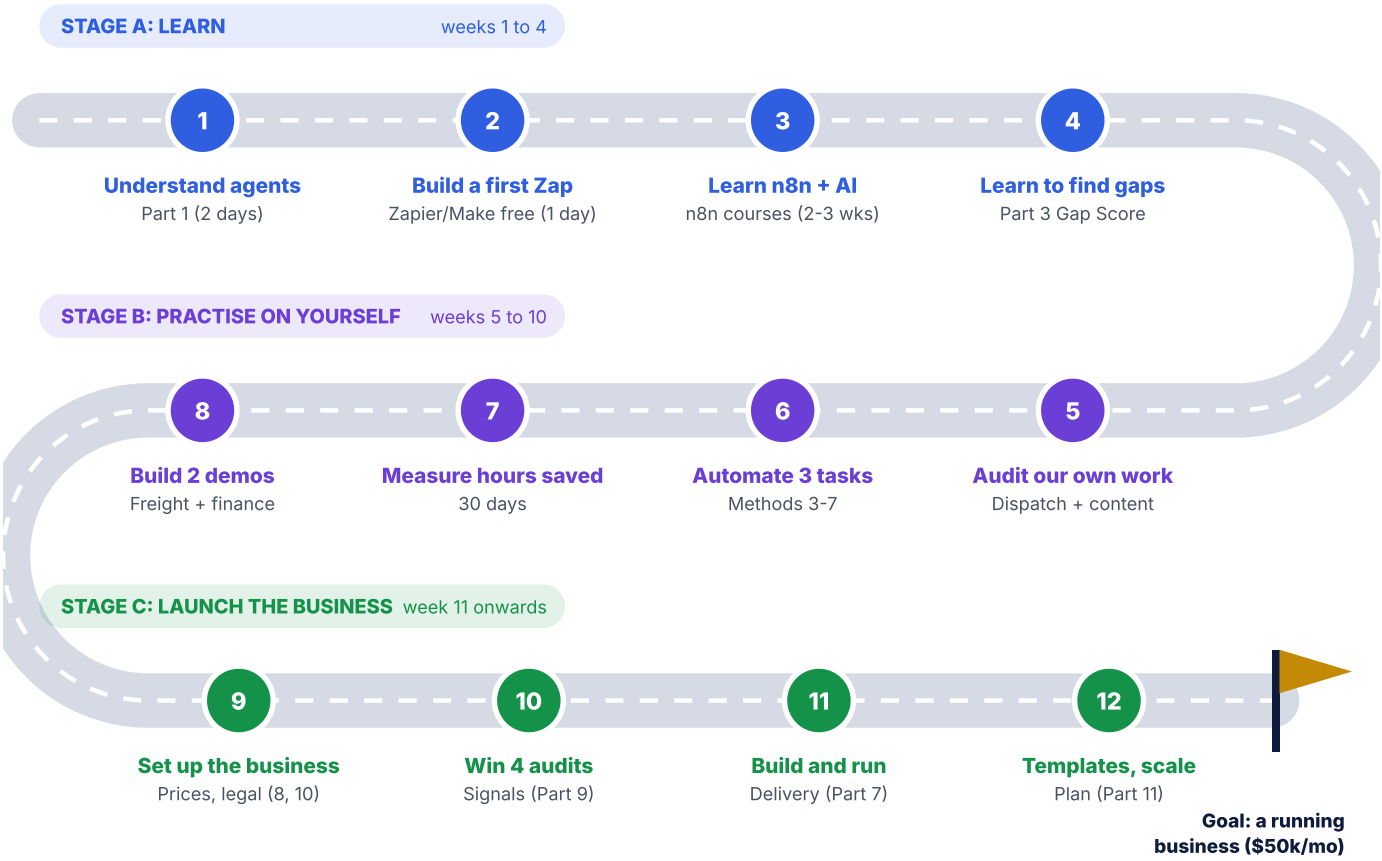
Question	Short answer
What is it?	We find repetitive work inside a company and replace it with automations (n8n, Make, Zapier), custom AI assistants that know the company's data, and AI agents that complete multi-step tasks with human checks.
Why now?	AI can now read PDFs and emails, write replies and make simple decisions reliably. Gartner expects 40% of enterprise apps to include task-specific agents by end 2026, up from under 5% in 2025. Most small and mid-size firms have no one to build them.
How big is it?	AI agents market approx. $7.8B in 2025, forecast $52.6B by 2030 (about 46% a year). McKinsey says up to 30% of work hours could be automated by 2030.
Who pays us?	Freight brokers and logistics firms, accounting and CPA firms, finance teams, insurance agencies, distributors, e-commerce, property managers and service businesses with heavy admin.
What do we sell?	An audit ($500-$1,500), builds ($750 per workflow up to $5,000-$12,000 for a custom agent), and monthly care plans ($400-$2,500). AI and tool costs are passed through with a 15% margin.
Who does the work?	A 7-person Lahore delivery team for the first 10 clients: architect, 3 builders, AI/RAG engineer, QA, business analyst.
What do we earn?	Approx. $22,000 a month at 10 care-plan clients plus 2 new builds a month, at about 60% gross margin. $50k a month in about 15 months (estimate).
Startup cost?	Approx. $25,000 including running costs until breakeven (month 3-4).
Licence needed?	No. We need strong contracts, data agreements and security. Finance, health and legal data need extra care (GLBA, HIPAA, GDPR).
Biggest risk?	AI mistakes in real operations. Every build has human approval points, logs, testing on real samples and a monitoring plan.
Decision	**GO.** Start with freight/logistics (our network) and finance back-office (largest gap), then turn each build into a repeatable template.

How to read this guide

- **New to all this?** Start with the roadmap on the next page.
- **Parts 1-2** explain agents and why companies need them. **Part 3** shows how to find gaps. **Part 4** picks industries. **Part 5** is the finance deep-dive.
- **Parts 6-8** cover services, delivery, tools, methods and money. **Part 9** is where clients come from. **Parts 10-11** cover rules, risks and the launch plan.

Start here: your roadmap from zero to a running business

This page is for someone who has **never built an automation**. Follow the 12 stops in order. Finish one before moving to the next.



The golden rule of this roadmap

Automate our own company first. Our dispatch, brokerage and content teams have dozens of repetitive tasks. Automating 3 of them gives us real skill, real "hours saved" numbers and two live demos (freight and finance) before we sell to anyone.

R The 12 stops in detail

Stop	What you do	Tools	Time	Done when
1. Understand agents	Read Part 1: the 4 levels, the agent loop, RAG, guardrails.	This guide	2 days	You can explain automation vs agent in 2 minutes
2. Build a first Zap	Connect a form to a Google Sheet and Slack in Zapier or Make.	Zapier / Make free plan	1 day	It runs by itself 10 times
3. Learn n8n + AI	Self-host or use n8n cloud trial; build an email → AI → sheet flow.	n8n docs, courses	2-3 weeks	Learning path Level 1-2 passed (Part 7)
4. Learn to find gaps	Read Part 3; practise the Gap Score on 10 tasks.	Gap Score sheet	2 days	10 tasks scored
5. Audit our own work	Interview 5 people in dispatch and content; list 30 tasks with hours.	Sheets, Loom	1 week	Our top 10 gaps listed

Stop	What you do	Tools	Time	Done when
6. Automate 3 tasks	Methods 3-7: build, test, launch with approvals.	n8n, AI API, Slack	3-4 weeks	3 automations live
7. Measure hours saved	Track time before and after for 30 days.	Sheets	30 days	A real hours-saved number
8. Build 2 demos	A freight demo (rate con → TMS) and a finance demo (invoice → QuickBooks).	n8n, test accounts	2 weeks	2 recorded demo videos
9. Set up the business	Prices (Part 8), contracts and data agreements (Part 10).	US LLC, Stripe	1-2 weeks	Ready to sign a client
10. Win 4 audits	Job-ad signals, network, referral partners (Part 9).	Apollo, LinkedIn, Loom	3-6 weeks	4 paid audits
11. Build and run	Delivery process (Part 7); care plans live.	Full toolkit	Ongoing	Clients renew month 3
12. Templates, scale	Turn repeated builds into templates; add pods.	n8n templates	Ongoing	$50k a month

PART 1

The basics: automation, assistants and agents

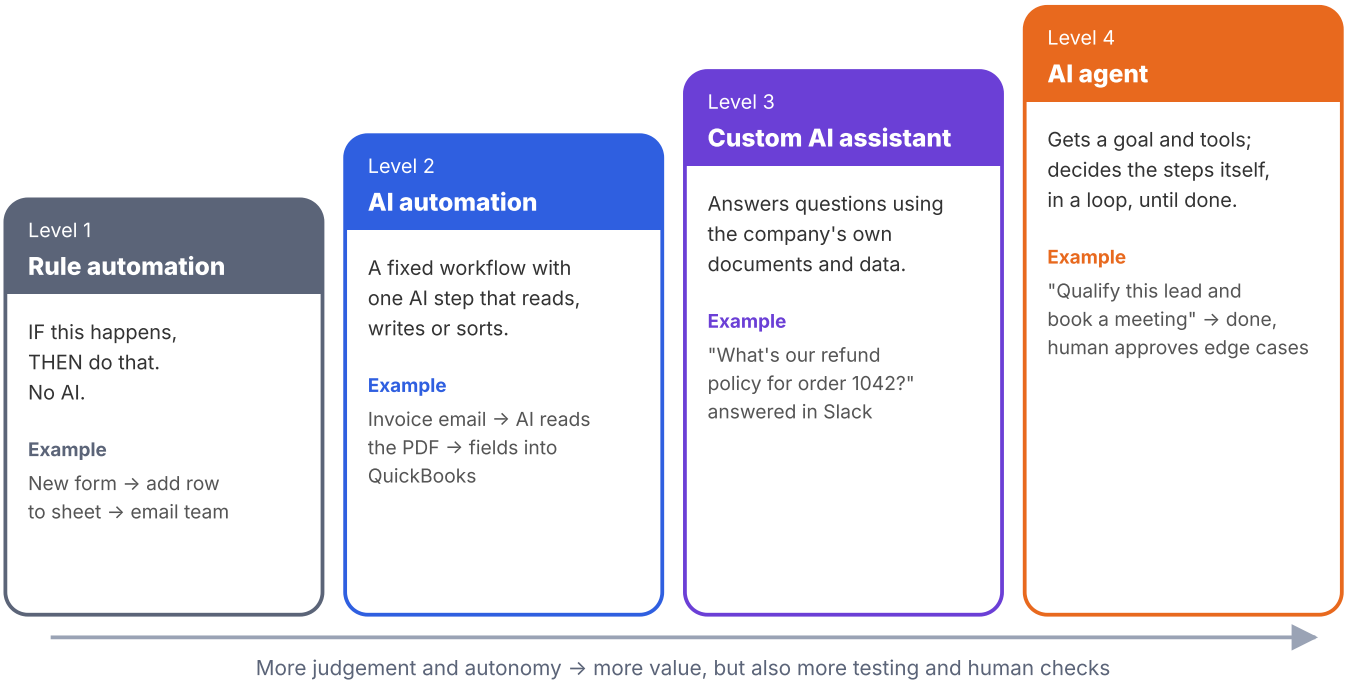
If you only read one part, read this one

1.1 The problem: people acting like copy-paste machines

Walk into almost any office and watch for an hour. Someone opens an email, downloads a PDF invoice, types the numbers into accounting software, and files the PDF. Someone else copies a load's details from an email into a TMS. Another person builds the same Excel report every Monday. These people are smart, but the computer is using them as a bridge between two systems.

Automation builds that bridge in software. **AI** makes the bridge smart enough to read messy emails and PDFs, write replies and make simple decisions. **Agents** let the software handle a whole multi-step job and ask a person only when something is unusual.

1.2 The four levels



Level	What it is	Typical price to build	Where it fits
1. Rule automation	Fixed IF/THEN steps between apps; no AI	$500-$1,500	Moving clean data between systems
2. AI automation	Fixed workflow with an AI step (read, extract, classify, write)	$1,500-$5,000	Invoices, emails, forms, documents
3. Custom AI assistant	Chat assistant that answers from the company's own files and data	$3,000-$8,000	Staff questions, SOPs, customer FAQs
4. AI agent	Gets a goal + tools; decides steps in a loop; humans approve exceptions	$5,000-$15,000	Lead qualification, ops coordination, multi-system tasks

Price ranges: Vantaige 2026 AI automation rate card (market-observed agency ranges, not guarantees).

1.3 How an AI agent works

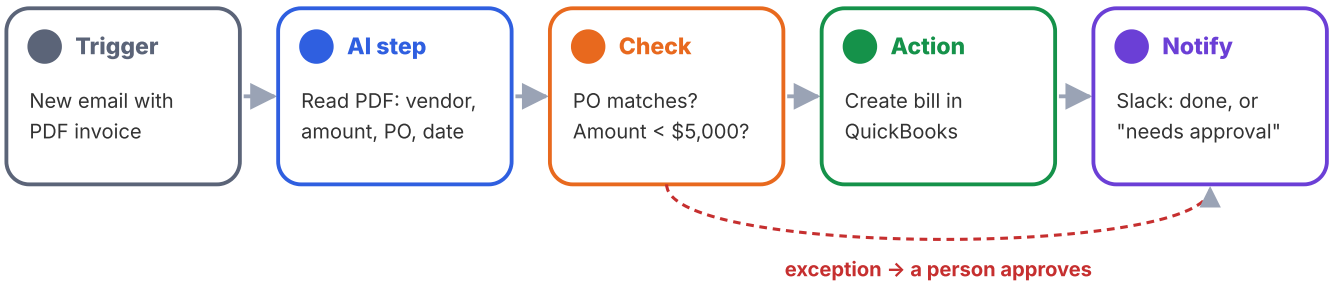
An agent is an AI model (the "brain") connected to **tools** (email, CRM, accounting software, a database) and given a **goal**. It plans a step, uses a tool, checks the result, and repeats until the goal is met. **Memory** lets it remember what it did and the company's rules. **Guardrails** set what it may never do alone, such as sending money or deleting records.



In one line: an automation follows a fixed path you drew; an agent chooses its own path toward a goal, inside limits you set.

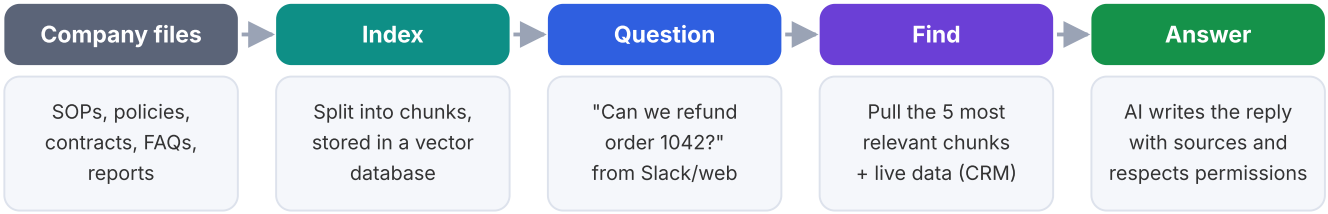
1.4 What a real workflow looks like

This is an AI automation (Level 2) for accounts payable, the kind we would build in n8n. Each box is a "node".



1.5 What a custom AI assistant is

A **custom AI assistant** is like ChatGPT, but it knows your company. It is connected to the company's own documents (SOPs, policies, price lists, contracts) and live systems (CRM, TMS, accounting), and it answers staff or customers in Slack, Teams, email or on the website, with sources.



This pattern is called RAG (retrieval-augmented generation): the AI looks things up before it answers.

Plain ChatGPT	Custom AI assistant
Knows the internet, not your company	Knows your SOPs, prices, policies, clients and history
Staff copy-paste data into it	Connected directly to CRM, TMS, accounting, shared drives
Everyone sees the same thing	Respects permissions: a dispatcher can't see payroll
No company log	Every question and answer logged; quality reviewed
Answers can drift from policy	Answers grounded in approved documents, with sources
Lives in a browser tab	Lives where work happens: Slack, Teams, email, website, phone

1.6 How agents handle repeated tasks

Rhythm	How it is triggered	Examples
Instant	Event: a new email, form, file, order or webhook	Invoice arrives → bill drafted; new lead → reply in 2 minutes
Every few minutes	Polling a system for changes	New loads on a board; status changes in a TMS
Daily	Schedule (e.g. 7 am)	Bank feed reconciliation; overdue invoice reminders; check-call summaries
Weekly / monthly	Schedule + calendar	Monday KPI report; month-end close checklist; variance commentary
On request	A person asks in Slack/Teams or clicks a button	"Summarise this contract"; "Draft the client update"

Agents work through a **queue**: each item (an invoice, a lead, a load) is processed the same way, retried if a system is down, and sent to a person if confidence is low. That is how one agent can do the repetitive part of the work of several people.

1.7 The tools

Tool	Best for	Price (approx.)	Note
Zapier	Simple jobs, non-technical clients, 7,000+ app connections	Free tier; paid from about $20/mo	Easiest; costly at high volume (billed per task)
Make	Visual, medium-complexity workflows	Free tier; from about $9/mo	Cheap; each module step counts as an operation
n8n	Complex workflows and AI agents (about 70 AI nodes)	Self-host free; cloud from about $22/mo	Billed per workflow run; our main tool
Voice platforms (Vapi, Retell)	AI phone calls	Per minute	Receptionist, check calls, reminders

Tool	Best for	Price (approx.)	Note
AI models (OpenAI, Anthropic, Google)	The brain inside workflows and agents	Per token (usage)	Billed to client at cost + 15%
Vector databases (Supabase, Pinecone)	Memory and document search for assistants	Free tier + usage	Needed for RAG

Prices from comparison articles (Digidop 2026); confirm on vendor pages.

What agents are NOT good at (yet)

- Decisions with legal, medical or large financial consequences without a human check.
- Tasks with no written rules where experts disagree.
- Work on paper or in systems with no API or export (possible, but slower and fragile).
- Being 100% accurate: plan for 90-98% plus human review of exceptions.

PART 2

Why companies need it, and how big it is

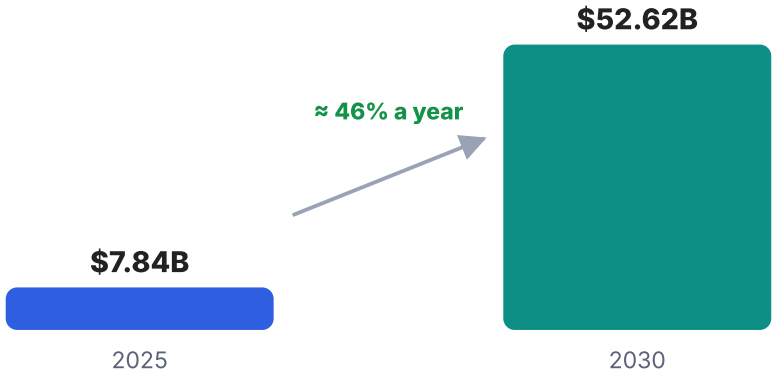
The business case, the numbers and the ROI

2.1 Why companies need automation and agents

Pain	What it costs the company	What we change
Staff shortage	The US has more than 120,000 accounting and auditing openings a year (BLS, via Beancount); dispatch and admin roles are hard to fill	Agents do the repetitive part; staff do review and judgement
High salaries	A US admin or AP clerk often costs $45,000-$60,000+ a year with benefits (approx.)	One build can remove 10-30 hours a week of that work
Slow response	Leads go cold after minutes; customers wait for replies	Replies in minutes, 24/7
Errors	Typos in invoices, wrong rates, missed renewals	Same rules every time, with checks
No visibility	Reports built by hand, always late	Live dashboards and daily summaries
Growth limits	More volume means more hires	Volume grows without the same hiring

2.2 The market

Global AI agents market (US$ billion, MarketsandMarkets via CMARIX)



Gartner:

40%

of enterprise apps with task-specific agents by end 2026 (from <5%)

Statistic	Figure	Source
Organisations engaged with AI agents	62% (23% scaling, 39% experimenting)	McKinsey, via CMARIX
Organisations using AI in at least one function	88%	McKinsey, via CMARIX
Work hours that could be automated by 2030	Up to 30%	McKinsey, via LetsDataScience (Apr 2026)
Enterprise apps with task-specific agents	40% by end 2026, from under 5% in 2025	Gartner, via CMARIX
US small businesses	≈ 36.2 million; 52% outsource some marketing	Hostinger, citing SBA/Statista

Big companies have IT teams and consultancies. The gap is the **small and mid-size firm** (10-500 staff) that has the same repetitive work but no one to build automations. That is our market.

2.3 Why a custom AI agent instead of off-the-shelf software?

Reason	Explanation
Their process is unique	Every broker, CPA firm or distributor has its own steps, exceptions and systems. Off-the-shelf tools cover 60%; the last 40% is where the hours are.
Their systems don't talk	TMS, QuickBooks, Gmail, Excel and a portal: an agent connects all of them.
Their data must stay private	A custom build controls where data goes, who sees it, and keeps logs.
Cheaper than another hire	A $6,000 build plus $1,200 a month is far less than a US hire, and it works 24/7.
Competitive edge	Faster quotes, faster replies and fewer errors win customers.

2.4 A simple ROI example (made-up client)

Item	Before	After automation
Invoices processed per month	1,200	1,200
Minutes per invoice (typing + checking)	6	1 (review exceptions only)
Staff hours per month	120	20
Cost at $30/hour fully loaded (US)	$3,600 / month	$600 / month
Our price	-	$6,000 build + $1,200 / month care plan
Client saving	-	≈ $1,800 / month after our fee; build paid back in about 3-4 months

Illustration only. Real savings come from the audit (Method 2). Always show the client their own numbers.

PART 3

Where to find the gap

How to spot repetitive work worth automating, inside any company

3.1 The 10 signals that a company has a gap

Signal	What it looks like	Where you can see it from outside
Job ads for repetitive roles	Hiring "data entry", "AP clerk", "billing specialist", "dispatcher", "admin coordinator"	Indeed, LinkedIn Jobs, company careers page
Excel everywhere	Weekly reports, trackers and rate sheets built by hand	Job ads asking for "advanced Excel"; the audit
PDFs typed into systems	Invoices, rate cons, purchase orders, forms	Job ads mentioning "data entry from documents"
Same email answered 20 times	Order status, quotes, "where is my load"	Website contact pages; slow reply times
Two systems with no link	Copying from CRM to accounting, TMS to QuickBooks	Tech stack (job ads, BuiltWith, G2 reviews)
Missed calls and slow leads	No reply after hours; leads wait a day	Call them at 7 pm; submit a test form
Month-end takes 10+ days	Close, reconciliations, reports	Finance job ads; CFO posts on LinkedIn
Growing fast	More volume than staff	Funding news, new locations, hiring sprees
Bad reviews about speed	"Never called back", "slow invoices"	Google, Yelp, Trustpilot reviews
Owner doing admin	Founder sends invoices and reports at night	Small firms; ask in the discovery call

The strongest signal: job ads

A company advertising for a "data entry clerk" or "accounts payable specialist" is telling the world it has repetitive work and a budget of $40,000-$60,000 a year for it. That job ad is our lead list. We send a short video showing how we would automate 3 tasks from the job description.

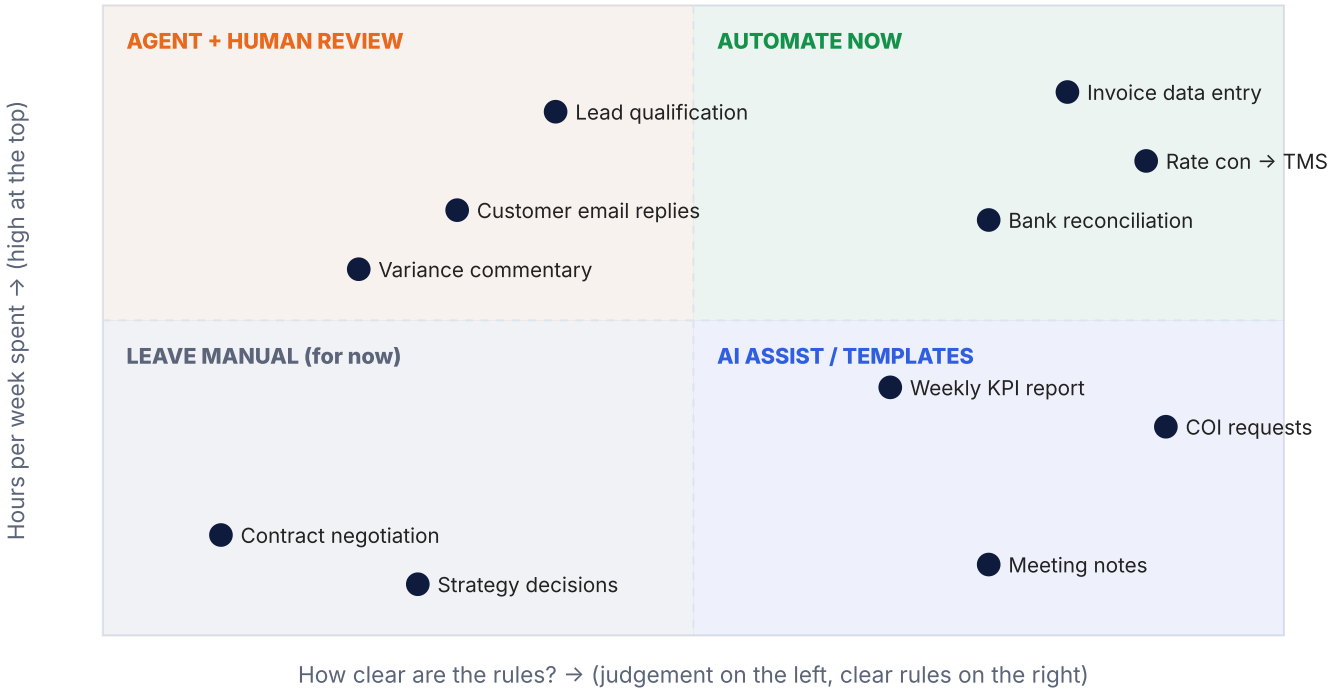
3.2 The Gap Score: should we automate this task?

Score every task from 1 to 5 on five questions. Add them up (maximum 25).

Question	1 (low)	5 (high)
Volume: how many hours a week does it take?	Under 1 hour	20+ hours
Repeatable: is it the same steps each time?	Different every time	Identical steps
Rules: are the decisions written down?	Pure judgement	Clear rules
Digital: is the data in email, PDF, apps?	Paper or phone only	All digital, systems have APIs
Low risk: what if it goes wrong once?	Big money or legal harm	Easy to fix

Total score	What to do
20-25	**Automate now** with rules + AI; light human review
14-19	**Agent with human approval** at key steps
9-13	**AI assist:** templates, drafts and suggestions; a person decides
Under 9	**Leave manual** for now

3.3 The gap map



3.4 The 15 most automatable tasks we see

Department	Tasks
Finance & admin	Invoice data entry (AP); bank and card reconciliation; overdue invoice reminders (AR); expense receipt matching; month-end checklists
Operations	Document intake to system (rate cons, POs, forms); status updates to customers; scheduling and dispatch support; certificate and compliance tracking
Sales & leads	Lead capture, enrichment and routing; instant first reply and qualification; meeting booking and CRM updates
Customer support	Ticket triage and tagging; draft replies for common questions
Reporting	Weekly KPI reports and dashboards built automatically

PART 4

Industries and sectors to target

Where the repetitive work is, who buys, and where we start

4.1 Heat map: where the work is

	Finance & admin	Operations	Sales & leads	Customer support	Reporting
Freight & logistics	5	5	4	4	4
Accounting / CPA firms	5	4	3	3	5
Insurance agencies	4	5	3	4	3
Distribution / wholesale	5	5	3	3	4
E-commerce	3	4	3	5	4
Real estate & property mgmt	4	4	4	4	3
Home services	3	4	5	4	2
Staffing & recruiting	3	4	5	3	3
Law firms	3	3	4	3	2
Healthcare clinics	3	4	3	4	2

Score 1-5 = how much repetitive, rules-based, digital work we usually find there (our assessment from typical workflows; validate in audits).

4.2 Industry scorecard

Industry	Top tasks to automate	Buyer	Typical first deal	Fit
Freight brokerage & logistics	Rate con → TMS, load posting, check calls, carrier onboarding, POD + invoice matching	Owner, Ops manager	$5k-$12k + $1-2.5k/mo	★★★★★
Accounting / CPA firms	Client document collection, bank recs, AP capture, month-end reports, engagement letters	Partner, Ops manager	$4k-$10k + $1-2k/mo	★★★★★
SMB finance teams	AP, AR reminders, reconciliation, cash forecast, management pack	CFO, Controller	$5k-$15k + $1-2.5k/mo	★★★★★
Distribution / wholesale	Purchase orders from email/PDF → ERP, quote requests, stock alerts	COO, Ops manager	$6k-$15k + $1-2k/mo	★★★★
Insurance agencies	COI requests, renewals prep, policy checking, quote intake	Agency principal, Ops	$4k-$10k + $1-2k/mo	★★★★
E-commerce / DTC	Order status replies, returns, review requests, inventory alerts, feeds	Founder, Ops lead	$3k-$8k + $0.8-2k/mo	★★★★
Real estate & property management	Lead follow-up, maintenance tickets, lease data, tenant messages	Broker, Property manager	$3k-$8k + $0.8-1.5k/mo	★★★★
Home services	Missed-call text-back, booking, quotes, review requests	Owner, Office manager	$2k-$5k + $0.5-1k/mo	★★★

Industry	Top tasks to automate	Buyer	Typical first deal	Fit
Staffing & recruiting	Resume screening, outreach, interview scheduling, CDL driver recruiting	Agency owner, Recruiting lead	$4k-$10k + $1-2k/mo	★★★★
B2B SaaS & agencies	Lead routing, CRM hygiene, onboarding, reporting	RevOps, COO	$4k-$12k + $1-2.5k/mo	★★★★
Law firms	Client intake, document first drafts, deadline tracking, updates	Managing partner	$4k-$10k + $1-2k/mo	★★★ (confidentialit
Healthcare clinics	Reminders, intake forms, insurance checks, reviews	Practice manager	$3k-$8k + $1-2k/mo	★★★ (HIPAA)

Deal sizes are our planned prices, below typical US agency rates. Fit = size of gap × ease of selling for us × compliance load.

4.3 Our three beachheads

1 Freight brokerage and logistics (start here)

WHY CLIENTS WANT IT	Brokers live in email: rate cons, BOLs, PODs, carrier packets, check calls. Margins are thin, so every hour saved matters.
WHAT WE DELIVER	Rate con email → AI reads → load created in TMS; carrier onboarding checks; automated check-call summaries and customer updates; POD + invoice matching; load board posting.
PRICING	Audit $750; build $5,000-$12,000; care plan $1,000-$2,500/mo; or per load $0.50-$2.
WHERE CLIENTS ARE	Our own broker and carrier network; TIA (Transportation Intermediaries Association) members; freight Facebook and LinkedIn groups; DAT/Truckstop users.
WHY IT FITS YOU	We already run this work in Lahore. Our own dispatch is the first case study.

2 Finance and accounting back office

WHY CLIENTS WANT IT	Accountant shortage (120,000+ US openings a year), month-end close delays, and Excel-heavy reporting.
WHAT WE DELIVER	AP invoice agent, bank reconciliation assistant, AR reminders, client document chasing for CPA firms, automated management pack. See Part 5.
PRICING	Audit $1,000; build $4,000-$15,000; care plan $1,000-$2,500/mo.
WHERE CLIENTS ARE	CPA firm owners (state CPA societies, AICPA ENGAGE, accounting LinkedIn), controllers and CFOs, QuickBooks/Xero app marketplaces, fractional CFO firms as partners.
WATCH	Data security, GLBA, Section 7216 for tax data; no autonomous payments.

3 B2B sales and operations (across all industries)

WHY CLIENTS WANT IT	Every company wants faster lead replies, cleaner CRM data and booked meetings.
WHAT WE DELIVER	Lead capture → enrichment → AI qualification → booking → CRM update; inbound reply agent; weekly pipeline report.
PRICING	Build $3,000-$8,000; care plan $800-$2,000/mo; or $75-$150 per booked meeting.
WHERE CLIENTS ARE	Our GEO and AI Ads clients, B2B SaaS, agencies, professional services.
WATCH	Cold email and calling rules (CAN-SPAM, PECR, TCPA).

PART 5

Finance analysis and back-office agents

Replacing Excel-heavy, repetitive finance work

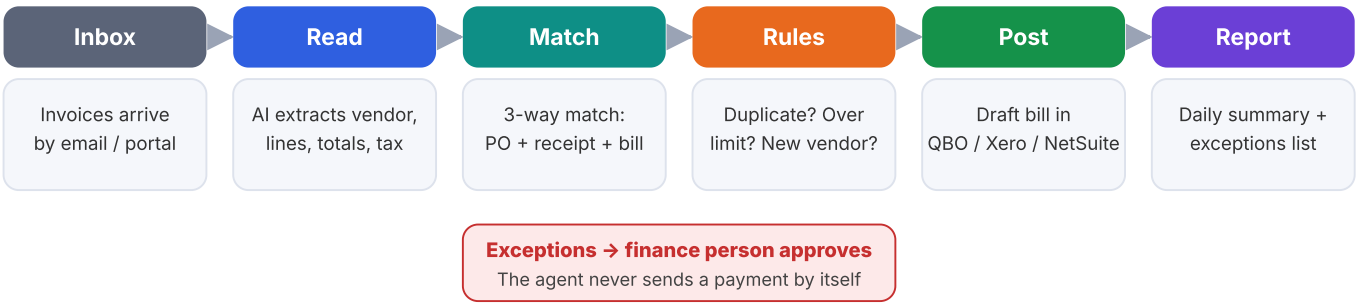
Finance is where the gap is largest. Most firms with $2M-$50M revenue still close the month, reconcile accounts and build reports by hand in Excel. Agents can do the repetitive parts, while people keep approvals and judgement.

5.1 Finance use cases

Use case	What the agent does	Human keeps	Typical time saved (est.)
AP invoice processing	Reads invoices, 3-way match, flags duplicates, drafts bills	Approves exceptions and payments	70-85% of entry time
Bank and card reconciliation	Matches transactions daily, suggests categories, lists unmatched	Reviews unmatched items	50-70%
AR collections	Sends polite reminders by schedule, logs replies, escalates	Handles disputes	60-80%
Month-end close assistant	Runs the checklist, pulls balances, chases owners, tracks status	Signs off the close	2-4 days faster close
Variance analysis and commentary	Compares actual vs budget, writes first-draft explanations	Edits and approves commentary	50-70% of report writing
13-week cash forecast	Pulls AR, AP and bank data weekly into a forecast	Adjusts assumptions	Hours → minutes
Expense audit	Checks receipts against policy, flags outliers	Decides on flagged items	60-80%
Management pack / board report	Builds the monthly pack from live data	Reviews the story	1-2 days per month
CPA client document collection	Requests, tracks and files client documents	Reviews completeness	50-70% of admin

Time-saved figures are our planning estimates for typical small/mid-size firms; measure in the audit.

5.2 How an AP invoice agent works



5.3 Finance analysis agent: from Excel to answers

Instead of exporting to Excel every month, the agent connects to the accounting system (QuickBooks Online, Xero, NetSuite) and the bank feed, refreshes a dashboard, and answers questions in plain English with numbers and sources:

- "Why is gross margin down 3 points this month?" → shows the 3 biggest cost lines that moved, with a draft explanation.
- "Which customers are over 60 days late?" → list with amounts and last contact.
- "What will cash look like in 6 weeks if payroll goes up 10%?" → updated 13-week forecast.
- "Draft this month's variance commentary." → first draft for the controller to edit.

Layer	Tools
Data	QuickBooks Online, Xero, NetSuite, Stripe, bank feeds, Google Sheets
Automation	n8n (scheduled pulls, checks, alerts), Make for simpler flows
Analysis	Python or SQL for calculations (AI should not do arithmetic by itself), Power BI or Looker Studio dashboards
AI	LLM for reading documents, writing commentary and answering questions, always citing the numbers it used
Delivery	Slack/Teams assistant, email summary, dashboard

Finance guardrails (non-negotiable)

- The agent **never sends payments** or posts final journal entries without human approval.
- Read-only access first; write access only for drafts.
- Segregation of duties: the person who approves is not the person who set up the vendor.
- Full audit trail: every action logged with time, input and output.
- Calculations done by code, not by the AI model; AI explains, code calculates.
- Public companies: follow the client's SOX controls; we document every automated control.

PART 6

The services we sell

Eleven services, each on a card

We price below typical US agency rates because delivery is in Lahore, while keeping senior review on every build. AI model and tool costs are billed to the client at cost + 15%.

1 Automation Audit (the front door)

WHAT IT IS	We interview staff, list every repetitive task, score each with the Gap Score, and estimate hours and dollars saved.
WHAT WE DELIVER	Task inventory, top-10 opportunities, ROI estimate, build plan and fixed quote.
PRICING	$500 (small business) or $1,500 (mid-market); credited to the first build.
TIME TO RESULT	5-10 working days.
KPIS TO TRACK	Audit-to-build conversion (target 60%).

2 Quick-win workflows

WHAT IT IS	Single automations between apps, with or without one AI step.
PRICING	$750-$1,500 each; 3 for $2,000.
EXAMPLE	New web form → CRM → Slack alert → welcome email.
TOOLS	Zapier or Make for simple, n8n for volume.

3 Workflow pack (one department)

WHAT IT IS	3-5 connected workflows that automate a department's routine.
PRICING	$3,000-$6,000.
EXAMPLE	Sales: lead capture, enrichment, routing, follow-ups, weekly report.

4 Document processing (AI intake)

WHAT IT IS	AI reads PDFs, emails and forms and enters data into systems.
PRICING	$3,000-$8,000 build + $0.50-$3 per document or care plan.
EXAMPLE	Rate cons → TMS; invoices → QuickBooks; POs → ERP.
RISKS	Messy documents; we test on 50+ real samples first.

5 Custom AI assistant (company knowledge)

WHAT IT IS	A RAG assistant over the company's files and systems, in Slack, Teams or on the website.
PRICING	$3,000-$8,000 setup + $500-$1,500/mo.
EXAMPLE	SOP assistant for dispatchers; HR policy bot; customer FAQ assistant.
RISKS	Out-of-date documents; we set an owner and a review schedule.

6 Custom AI agent (sales, ops or support)

WHAT IT IS	A goal-driven agent with tools and approval points.
PRICING	$5,000-$12,000 + $750-$2,000/mo.
EXAMPLE	Lead qualification + booking agent; check-call agent; ticket triage agent.
RISKS	Needs evaluation on real cases and clear limits.

7 Finance automation pack

WHAT IT IS	AP agent, reconciliation assistant, AR reminders and a management dashboard.
PRICING	$6,000-$15,000 + $1,000-$2,500/mo.
WHO BUYS	Controllers, CFOs, CPA firms (white-label for their clients).

8 Freight operations pack

WHAT IT IS	Rate con intake, carrier onboarding, check-call summaries, POD/invoice matching.
PRICING	$5,000-$12,000 + $1,000-$2,500/mo, or per load.
WHO BUYS	Freight brokers, 3PLs, carriers with office staff.

9 AI voice agent

WHAT IT IS	An AI that answers or makes routine calls: booking, reminders, status updates.
PRICING	$1,500-$3,000 setup + $300-$1,000/mo + per-minute costs.
RISKS	TCPA consent for outbound calls; disclose AI where required.

10 Care plan (monitoring and improvement)

WHAT IT IS	We watch every automation, fix breaks, update prompts and add small improvements.
PRICING	Basic $400/mo (1-2 flows), Growth $1,200/mo (3-8 flows), Ops $2,500/mo (SLA, dashboard, monthly strategy).
KPIS TO TRACK	Uptime, error rate, hours saved, monthly churn.

11 White-label for agencies and CPA firms

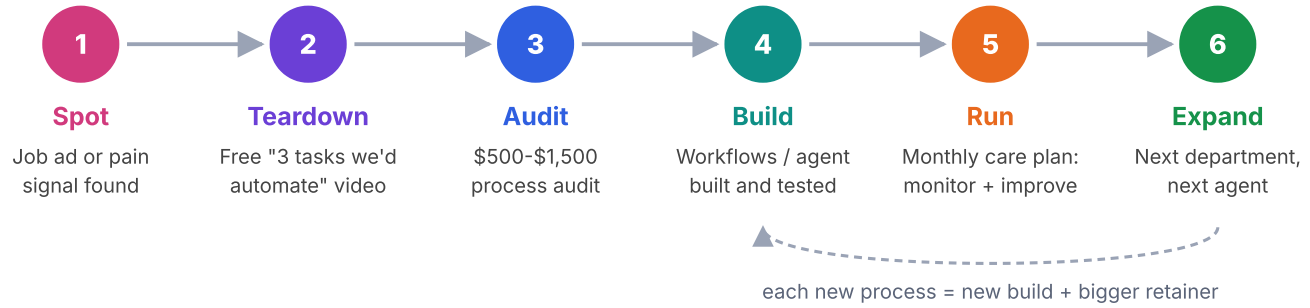
WHAT IT IS	We build and run automations for other agencies' and accountants' clients, under their brand.
PRICING	30% below list.
RISKS	Partner concentration; cap any partner at 25% of revenue.

PART 7

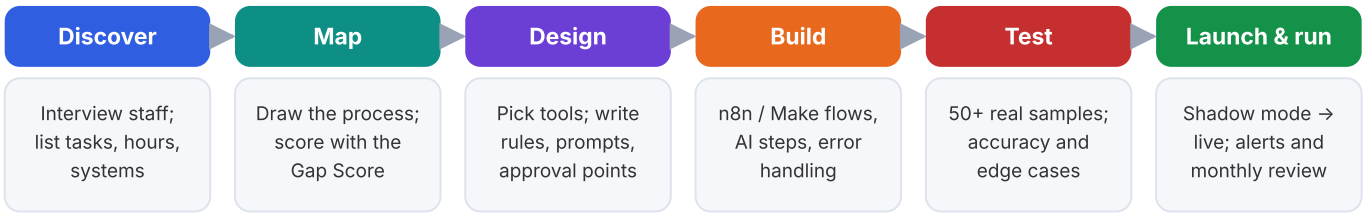
How the work gets done: toolkit and methods

Delivery process, team, tools to learn and step-by-step methods

7.1 The client journey

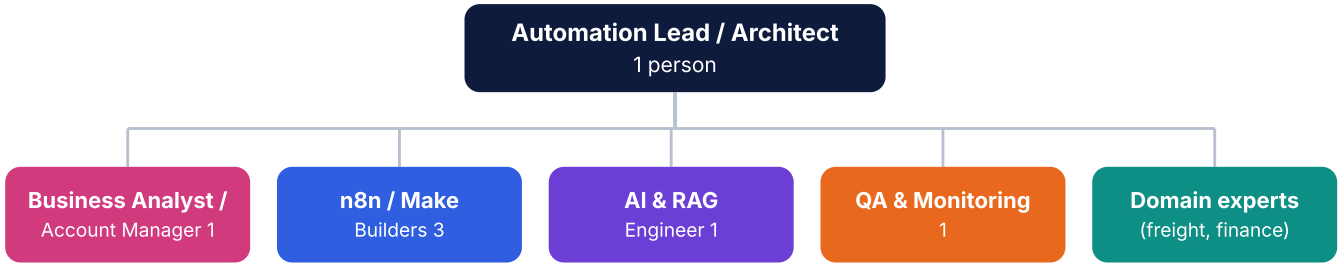


7.2 Our delivery process for every build



Shadow mode means the automation runs next to the person for 1-2 weeks: it prepares the work, the person checks it, and we measure accuracy before switching it fully on.

7.3 The team in Lahore (first 10 clients)



+ 2 SDRs (sales); domain experts borrowed part-time

Role	People	Main job	Monthly salary each (PKR, approx.)
Automation lead / architect	1	Designs every solution, reviews builds, client calls	400,000
Business analyst / account manager	1	Audits, process maps, client contact (US/UK hours)	250,000
n8n / Make builders	3	Build and test workflows	200,000

Role	People	Main job	Monthly salary each (PKR, approx.)
AI and RAG engineer	1	Prompts, assistants, vector search, evaluation	300,000
QA and monitoring	1	Testing on real samples, alerts, fixes	120,000
SDRs (sales)	2	Job-ad research, teardown videos, booking calls	100,000

Our estimates with a premium for international work; senior Pakistani tech marketers earn roughly PKR 140,000-220,000+ (IDT Pakistan, 2026); strong automation engineers earn more. 1 USD ≈ 280 PKR. Freight and finance staff from our other businesses act as domain experts part-time.

7.4 Tools to learn, by role and in order

Level	Tool / skill	Who	Learn free at	Skill test	Hours
1	Zapier and Make basics	Builders, BA	Zapier Learn; Make Academy	Form → Sheet → Slack flow running	4
1	n8n fundamentals	Builders, Lead	n8n docs and courses (docs.n8n.io)	Email → AI → sheet workflow with error branch	12
1	APIs, JSON and webhooks	Builders, AI eng.	n8n docs; Postman learning centre	Call a REST API and map its JSON	6
1	Prompt writing for business tasks	Everyone	Anthropic / OpenAI prompting guides	Extraction prompt with 95%+ accuracy on 20 samples	4
1	Process mapping	BA, Lead	Any BPMN/flowchart intro; Miro	Map one real process end to end	3
2	AI agents in n8n (tools, memory)	AI eng., Lead	n8n AI agent docs	Agent that uses 2 tools and asks for approval	10
2	RAG and vector databases	AI eng.	Supabase / Pinecone docs	Assistant answers 20 SOP questions with sources	10
2	Document AI / OCR	Builders	Vendor docs (e.g. Google Document AI, Azure)	Extract 10 fields from 50 invoices	6
2	QuickBooks / Xero / NetSuite APIs	Builders (finance)	Intuit and Xero developer docs	Create a draft bill via API in a sandbox	6
2	TMS and load board integrations	Builders (freight)	Vendor API docs	Create a test load via API or email parsing	6
2	Monitoring and error handling	QA	n8n error workflows; Better Stack docs	Alert fires when a flow fails	4
3	Python / SQL for finance calcs	AI eng., Builders	Free Python and SQL courses	Reconcile 2 CSVs with a script	15
3	Voice agents (Vapi / Retell)	AI eng.	Vendor docs	Inbound call books a test appointment	6
3	Security basics (secrets, access, logs)	Everyone	OWASP basics; vendor security docs	Credentials stored in a vault; least-access review	4

7.5 The 10 core methods

Method 1 Run a discovery interview

Why: The best automations come from watching real work, not from guessing.

1. Interview 3-5 people who do the work (30 minutes each).
2. Ask: "Walk me through yesterday. What did you copy, type or chase?"
3. Screen-record one full task with Loom.
4. Write every task: frequency, minutes, systems, inputs, outputs, exceptions.
5. Ask what goes wrong and how often.

Tools: Loom, Google Sheets, Miro **You end with:** A task inventory with hours per week

```
Task inventory columns
Task | Who | Times/week | Minutes each | Hours/week | Systems | Input (email/PDF/app) | Output | Exceptions
| Gap Score
```

Method 2 Score and price the opportunity

Why: Clients buy ROI. Show their own numbers.

1. Score each task with the Gap Score (Part 3).
2. Hours/week × 52 × loaded hourly cost = yearly cost of the task.
3. Estimate the share automatable (from the score).
4. Pick the top 3 by savings ÷ build effort.
5. Quote a fixed price and show payback months.

Tools: Gap Score sheet **You end with:** A one-page ROI and quote

```
Yearly cost      = hours per week x 52 x hourly cost
Yearly saving    = yearly cost x share automatable
Payback (months) = build price / (monthly saving - care plan fee)
Example: 30 h/wk x 52 x $30 = $46,800; 70% automatable = $32,760/yr = $2,730/mo
Build $6,000, care $1,200/mo -> payback = 6,000 / (2,730 - 1,200) = 3.9 months
```

Method 3 Design the workflow on paper first

Why: A clear design avoids rebuilds.

1. Draw trigger → steps → actions → notifications.
2. Mark every decision: rule or AI?
3. Mark approval points and limits (e.g. over $5,000 → human).
4. List the data fields and where each comes from.
5. Agree the design with the client before building.

Tools: Miro or Excalidraw, design template **You end with:** A signed-off one-page design

Method 4 Build in n8n with error handling

Why: Workflows break when systems change; plan for it.

1. Create the trigger (webhook, email, schedule).
2. Add each step; test with real sample data.
3. Add an error branch that logs and alerts on any failure.
4. Use retries for network calls.
5. Store credentials in n8n credentials, never in nodes or code.
6. Name and annotate every node.

Tools: n8n, client test accounts **You end with:** A working workflow with error alerts

Method 5 Write reliable AI extraction prompts

Why: AI steps must return the same structure every time.

1. Tell the model its role and the exact fields to return.
2. Ask for JSON only, with field types.
3. Give 2-3 examples of real documents and correct outputs.
4. Ask it to return null when unsure, never to guess.
5. Test on 50+ real samples and record accuracy per field.

Tools: LLM API, test sheet **You end with:** A prompt with measured accuracy

```
System: You extract data from freight rate confirmations.
Return ONLY valid JSON with these fields:
{"broker":string,"load_number":string,"pickup_date":"YYYY-MM-DD",
 "pickup_city":string,"delivery_city":string,"rate_usd":number,"equipment":string}
If a field is missing or unclear, return null for it. Never guess numbers.
```

Method 6 Add human-in-the-loop approvals

Why: Approvals let us automate risky steps safely.

1. Decide the rules: amount limits, new vendors, low AI confidence.
2. Send the item to Slack/Teams/email with Approve / Reject buttons.
3. Wait for the decision; time-out and escalate if no answer.
4. Log who approved and when.

Tools: n8n wait/approval nodes, Slack **You end with:** Safe automation of high-value steps

Method 7 Build a custom AI assistant (RAG)

Why: Staff and customers get answers from approved company knowledge.

1. Collect the source documents and name an owner for each.
2. Clean and split them; store embeddings in a vector database.
3. Write the assistant's rules: answer only from sources, cite them, say "I don't know".
4. Connect it to Slack, Teams or the website.
5. Test with 30 real questions; fix gaps in documents.
6. Review logs weekly in the first month.

Tools: n8n AI nodes, Supabase/Pinecone, LLM **You end with:** An assistant that answers with sources

Method 8 Test with real samples and shadow mode

Why: Proves accuracy before the client depends on it.

1. Collect 50-100 real past items (invoices, emails, loads).
2. Run them through; compare with the correct result.
3. Fix prompts and rules until accuracy meets the target (e.g. 97%).
4. Run 1-2 weeks in shadow mode next to staff.
5. Switch on fully; keep exceptions going to people.

Tools: Test sheet, n8n **You end with:** A measured accuracy report signed off by the client

Method 9 Monitor and improve (care plan)

Why: Recurring revenue comes from keeping automations healthy.

1. Daily: check error alerts and failed runs.
2. Weekly: review exceptions and AI mistakes; update prompts.
3. Monthly: report hours saved, volume, errors and next ideas.
4. Quarterly: review access, credentials and costs.

Tools: n8n executions, Better Stack, Looker Studio **You end with:** A monthly care report

Method 10 Turn builds into templates

Why: Templates make the 5th build 3x faster and more profitable.

1. After each build, remove client-specific parts.
2. Save as a template with a setup checklist.
3. Write a 1-page "what it does" sales sheet.
4. Record a 3-minute demo video.
5. Price templates as fixed packages.

Tools: n8n templates, Loom **You end with:** A growing library of packaged solutions

PART 8

The money: prices, costs and revenue

What we charge, what we spend, and what we can earn

8.1 How the market charges

Item	Market range	Our price
Audit / discovery	$250-$1,000 small; $1,500-$5,000 mid-market	$500 / $1,500 (credited)
Simple workflow	$500-$2,000	$750-$1,500
Multi-tool workflow	$2,000-$5,000	$3,000-$6,000 (pack)
Custom agent	$5,000-$15,000	$5,000-$12,000
Monthly retainer	$300-$1,500 small; $1,500-$5,000 mid-market	$400 / $1,200 / $2,500
Per result	$50-$200 per meeting; $0.50-$5 per ticket	$75-$150 per meeting; $0.50-$3 per document
AI and tool costs	Passed through, 10-30% markup	At cost + 15%

Market ranges: Vantaige 2026 AI automation rate card.

8.2 Profit at 10 care-plan clients

Line	Per month
Care plans (4 × $400 + 4 × $1,200 + 2 × $2,500)	$11,400
New builds (average 2 a month × $5,300)	$10,600
Revenue	**$22,000**
Lahore delivery team (7 people) + 25% overhead	approx. $7,450
Software, hosting and tools	approx. $1,200
Gross profit	**approx. $13,350**
Gross margin	**approx. 61%**

Tool	Approx. monthly cost
n8n (self-hosted VPS for our demos + cloud plan for testing)	≈ $150
Make Pro + Zapier Team (for client work on those tools)	≈ $100
AI API credits for development and testing	≈ $200
Vector database, monitoring (Better Stack)	≈ $80
Google Workspace, ClickUp, HubSpot Starter	≈ $290
Loom, Miro	≈ $60
Apollo + Instantly (sales)	≈ $200
Buffer	≈ $120
Total	**≈ $1,200**

8.3 One client, in detail

Measure	Approx. value
Typical first build	$6,000
Delivery cost of that build (≈ 120 team hours)	$2,000
Care plan	$1,200 a month
Care plan delivery cost	$350 a month
Cost to win the client	$800-$1,500
Expected care-plan lifetime	≈ 18 months
Lifetime gross profit (build + care)	≈ $19,000
Expansion: a second build within 12 months	Expected for about half of clients

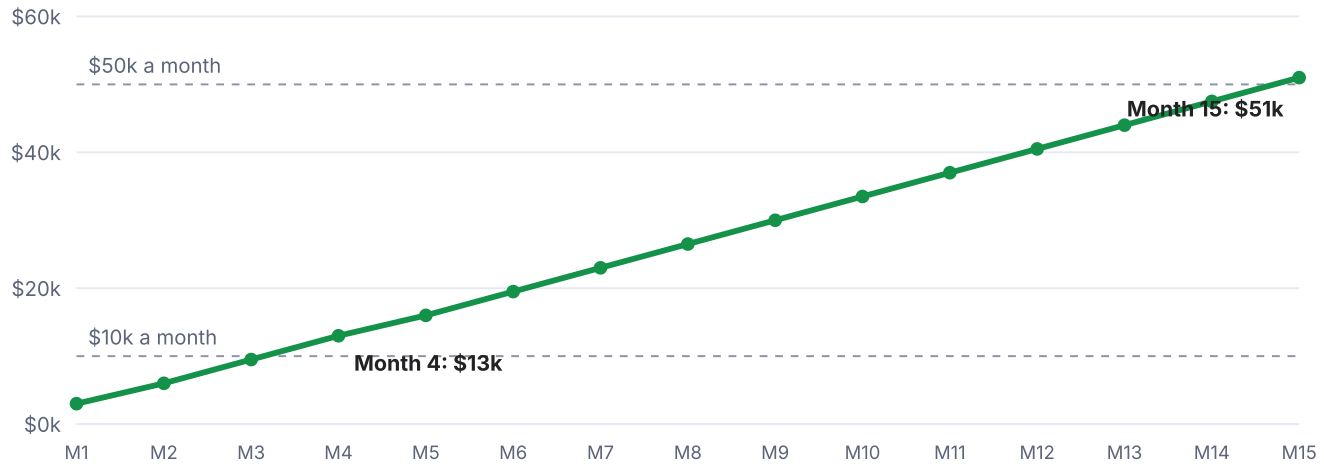
8.4 Startup cost

Item	Approx. cost
Legal: MSA, DPA, liability caps, IP clauses (US and UK/EU review)	$3,000
E&O and cyber insurance, first year	$3,000
Demo builds (freight + finance) and internal automations	$2,000
Website, case studies, demo videos	$1,500
Tools and API credits for the first months	$1,500
Training	$1,000
Running costs not covered, months 1-3	$8,000
Safety buffer	$5,000
Total	**≈ $25,000**

Build fees arrive up front (50% deposit), so cash flow is faster than in pure retainer businesses. Breakeven is about $9,000-$10,000 of monthly revenue, expected around **month 3 to 4**.

8.5 Revenue projection

Projected monthly revenue (builds + care plans), months 1 to 15 (estimate)



8.6 Three scenarios at month 12

	Slow	Base	Strong
Care-plan clients	8	18	30
New builds per month	1	2.5	4
Monthly revenue	≈ $15k	≈ $40k	≈ $70k
Team size	6	12	20
Gross margin	≈ 50%	≈ 60%	≈ 63%
What causes it	Few referrals; long sales cycles	Freight + finance templates sell; 3 referral partners	CPA white-label partner brings 10+ clients
What we do	Focus only on freight	Scale by pods; add a third vertical	Open a UK presence; productise templates

PART 9

Where clients come from, and how we sell

The channels, the funnel and ready-to-use scripts

9.1 Client sources

Where our first 30 clients are expected to come from (estimate, % of clients)



Channel	How it works	Cost
Warm network	Brokers, carriers, shippers we already work with; content and GEO clients. Offer an audit.	Almost free
Job-ad signals	Search Indeed/LinkedIn for "data entry", "AP clerk", "billing coordinator", "dispatcher" at US/UK firms with 10-500 staff. Send a 2-minute Loom: "3 tasks from your job ad we'd automate".	SDR time + Apollo
Referral partners	CPA firms, IT managed service providers (MSPs), marketing agencies, fractional CFOs. They have clients asking for AI; we pay 10-15% referral or offer white-label.	Referral fee
LinkedIn content	Weekly before/after demo videos: "This broker saved 25 hours a week."	Team time
Directories and marketplaces	n8n experts, Make partner and Zapier expert directories (apply once eligible); Upwork and Contra for first reviews.	Platform fees
Associations and events	TIA (freight brokers), state CPA societies, AICPA ENGAGE, IIABA (insurance agents), industry LinkedIn groups.	Membership / travel

9.2 The outbound funnel



One month of targeted outreach by 2 SDRs (estimate). Log scale so small stages stay readable.

9.3 Sample cold email (job-ad signal)

Subject: Your "[job title]" role: 3 tasks we'd automate

Hi [First name],

I saw you're hiring a [job title]. The ad mentions [task 1], [task 2] and [task 3]. Companies like yours usually spend 20-30 hours a week on these.

I recorded a 2-minute video showing how an AI workflow could handle them, with your team approving only the exceptions. Want me to send it?

[Your name]
[Company] | [Postal address]
Not relevant? Reply "no" and I won't email again.

9.4 Sample call script

1. Opener: "Hi [Name], it's [Me] from [Company]. We build AI workflows for [industry] teams. Quick question: who handles [task] today?"

2. Pain: "How many hours a week does that take? What happens when that person is out?"

3. Proof: "A [similar company] we worked with cut [task] from 25 hours to 4 hours a week, and their team only checks exceptions."

4. Offer: "We do a fixed-price audit: we map your top 10 repetitive tasks and show the savings. It's credited to the first build."

5. Close: "Would Tuesday or Thursday work for a 20-minute walkthrough?"

9.5 Sample referral partner message (CPA firm or MSP)

Hi [Name], your clients are probably asking about AI. We're an automation team that builds AI workflows for finance and operations (AP, reconciliations, reporting, document intake), with human approvals and full audit logs. We work white-label or on referral (15%). Could we show you a 10-minute demo of our invoice agent?

9.6 Where we sell first

Market	Why	Cold email rules
United States	Largest market; freight network; accountant shortage	CAN-SPAM: identity, address, opt-out
United Kingdom	Fits Lahore hours; strong SMB finance and logistics sector	PECR: corporate addresses, opt-out
Netherlands, Ireland, Nordics	English-friendly, high wages, logistics hubs	GDPR legitimate interest; document it
Germany	Large but strict	Consent needed even for B2B (UWG §7); use partners and LinkedIn

PART 10

Rules, security and risks

No licence is needed, but data and AI rules protect us and our clients

10.1 Legal and data rules

Rule	What it says, simply	What we do
GDPR / UK GDPR	Protect personal data of people in Europe and the UK; Pakistan has no EU adequacy decision	DPA + Standard Contractual Clauses (UK: IDTA/Addendum); least access
GLBA (US financial data)	Financial institutions must protect customer financial data, including through service providers	Security programme, access controls, logs; sign client's vendor terms
IRS Section 7216 (tax data)	Tax preparers need consent to disclose or use tax return information	Work only under the CPA firm's consent process; no reuse of data
HIPAA (US health data)	Protected health information needs a Business Associate Agreement	Sign a BAA or don't touch PHI; use HIPAA-eligible tools
EU AI Act, Article 50 (from 2 Aug 2026)	People must be told when they interact with AI; deepfakes labelled	Assistants and voice agents disclose they are AI
TCPA (US calls/texts)	Consent rules for automated calls and texts to mobiles	Inbound first; consent records for outbound
n8n licence	Building and running workflows for clients is allowed; hosting n8n as a service where clients build their own workflows is not	Run on the client's own n8n, or on ours without client access; ask n8n about embedding

n8n: docs.n8n.io licence FAQ. This is general information, not legal advice; budget a lawyer review.

10.2 Security standard for every client

- MFA on every account; company-managed laptops; no personal devices.
- Credentials stored in n8n credentials or a password vault, never in code or chat.
- Least-access: read-only until write is needed; separate test and live environments.
- Client owns all accounts (n8n, AI keys, apps); we are invited users.
- Logs kept for every run; personal data minimised in prompts.
- Use business/API tiers of AI providers whose terms say client data isn't used for training (check current terms).
- Prepare for SOC 2 once finance clients grow.

10.3 Main risks and how we handle them

Risk	What could go wrong	How we reduce it
AI mistakes	Wrong field extracted, wrong reply sent	Tests on real samples, confidence thresholds, human approvals, shadow mode
System changes	A client's app changes its API; flow breaks	Error alerts, care plan, quick-fix SLA
Liability	Client blames us for a financial loss	Contract: liability cap, client approves outputs, E&O insurance

Risk	What could go wrong	How we reduce it
Data breach	Credentials or data leak	Security standard above; cyber insurance
Tool lock-in / price rises	A platform raises prices	Prefer n8n (portable); document every flow
Commoditisation	Clients learn to build simple Zaps themselves	Focus on industry-specific, multi-system builds and care plans
Scope creep	"Small changes" never end	Fixed scope + change request process
Hiring	Few experienced automation engineers	Train our own; templates reduce skill needed

PART 11

Launch plan and decision

Score, 90-day plan and what to track

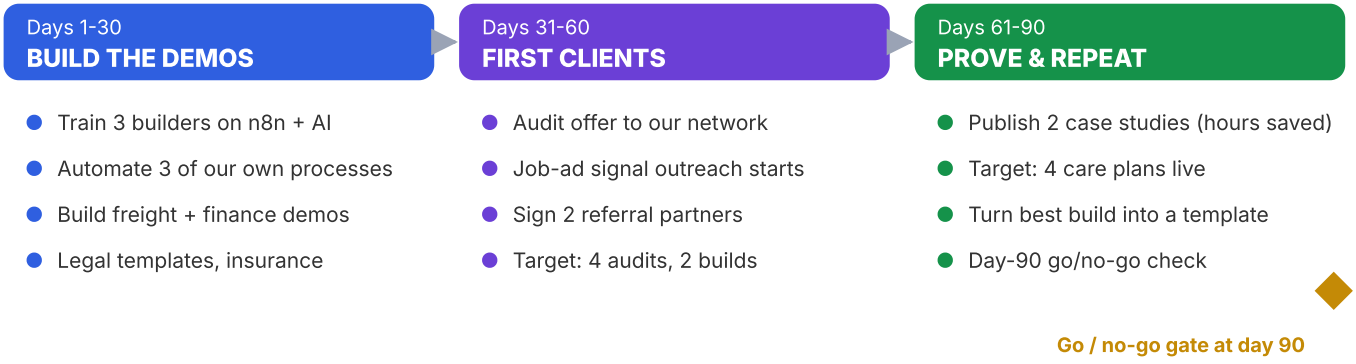
11.1 How this fits our existing businesses

Existing business	What it gives this venture
Freight brokerage and dispatch	Domain knowledge, first case study, and our network as first clients.
Content writing	Writers help with prompts, documentation and demo videos.
GEO and AI Ads	Every marketing client needs lead and reporting automation; easy cross-sell.
Finance back-office ideas	This venture is the delivery engine for AP, reconciliation and reporting services.
100-person operations team	Our own processes are the first automation lab.

11.2 Venture score

Criterion	Weight	Score (1-5)	Reason
Recurring revenue	20%	4	Care plans recur; builds are one-off but repeat with expansion
Remote-ability	20%	5	Everything is built and run online
Regulatory gate	15%	4	No licence, but finance/health data rules need care
Synergy with current businesses	15%	5	Freight domain, own processes as lab, cross-sell to GEO/Ads clients
Acquisition cost	10%	4	Job-ad signals and warm network are cheap; larger deals need calls
Labour arbitrage	10%	5	US automation engineers cost many times Lahore salaries
AI-disruption risk	10%	3	AI makes building easier, but clients still need someone to design, run and own it
Weighted total	**100%**	**4.35**	**Strong: launch**

11.3 The 90-day launch plan



Week	Key actions	Done when
1-2	Hire/assign the architect and 3 builders; start the learning path.	Training running

Week	Key actions	Done when
3-4	Audit our own dispatch and content work; automate 3 tasks.	3 internal automations live
5-6	Record freight and finance demos; legal templates and insurance.	2 demo videos; contracts ready
7-8	Audits offered to our network; job-ad outreach starts; approach 10 CPA firms/MSPs.	4 audits booked
9-10	First 2 builds in shadow mode.	Accuracy reports signed
11-12	Builds live; care plans signed; publish case studies; day-90 review.	4 care plans; go/no-go decided

Day-90 go / no-go test

Continue and scale if we have 4+ paying clients, at least 2 live builds with measured hours saved, and an audit-to-build rate of 50%+. **Otherwise**, narrow to freight automation only.

11.4 Numbers to watch every month

Area	KPI	Target
Sales	Teardowns sent / replies / calls / audits	120 / 30 / 12 / 5
Sales	Audit → build conversion	60%
Delivery	Accuracy on test samples before go-live	≥ 95-98% (per task)
Delivery	Hours saved per client per month	Tracked and reported
Money	Monthly revenue	$10k by month 4; $50k by month 15
Money	Gross margin	60%+
Clients	Care plan churn	< 4% a month
Product	Builds reused from templates	50%+ by month 9

11.5 Final recommendation

In one line: GO. The gap is large (repetitive work everywhere, staff shortages, few builders for small and mid-size firms), we have the freight domain and our own processes as a test lab, and Lahore delivery gives us a strong price advantage.

11.6 Open questions to check

- Which TMS platforms our first freight clients use, and their API access.
- E&O and cyber insurance quotes for automation work.
- Which AI providers' business terms fit finance and health clients.
- Referral terms that CPA firms and MSPs expect.
- Which of the 12 industries converts fastest in the first 20 audits.

Glossary: every new word in simple English

Word	Meaning
Automation	Software that does a task by itself when something happens.
Workflow	A chain of automated steps: trigger, steps, actions.
Trigger	The event that starts a workflow (new email, form, file, time).
Node	One step (box) in an n8n workflow.
Zapier / Make / n8n	Popular tools for building workflows between apps.
API	A doorway that lets one app send data to another.
Webhook	A message one app sends to another the moment something happens.
JSON	A simple text format for structured data.
LLM	Large language model, the AI brain (GPT, Claude, Gemini).
Prompt	The instructions given to the AI.
AI agent	An AI with a goal and tools that decides its own steps in a loop.
Custom AI assistant	A chat assistant that answers from a company's own data.
RAG	Retrieval-augmented generation: the AI looks up documents before answering.
Vector database	A database that finds text by meaning, used for RAG.
Human-in-the-loop	A person approves or corrects the AI at set points.
Shadow mode	The automation runs alongside staff before it goes live.
Guardrails	Limits on what an agent may do.
OCR / document AI	Reading text and fields from PDFs and images.
3-way match	Checking an invoice against the purchase order and the delivery receipt.
Reconciliation	Matching bank transactions with accounting records.
Variance analysis	Explaining differences between actual results and budget.
Care plan	Monthly fee to monitor, fix and improve automations.
Gap Score	Our 5-question score (max 25) to decide if a task should be automated.
SLA	Service level agreement: promised response or fix time.
MSP	Managed service provider: an IT support company, a good referral partner.
TMS	Transportation management system used by brokers and carriers.

Sources

Read in October 2026. Prices and market figures change often; check each source before deciding.

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